

The Neutral-Corner Protocol (The Whole Thing on One Page)

The complete tool from The 21-Minute Argument Fix by Simon Gebhart.

This page is the book. If you skipped straight here, you can run the entire protocol from this checklist — each line carries its evidence tag, and the chapters behind you hold the details and the caveats.

Part 1 — The 21 minutes (the core)

(Evidence: a 2-year randomized trial of 120 couples — three 7-minute reappraisal writing exercises per year eliminated the ongoing decline in marital quality that control couples kept experiencing, via reduced conflict-related distress. Single trial; it preserved quality, it did not boost it, and it didn't reduce fight frequency.)

- [] **Three 7-minute writing exercises per year.** After a significant disagreement, set a 7-minute timer and write about the fight from the perspective of a neutral third party who wants the best for everyone involved: What would they see happening? Where would they say the disagreement comes from? What blocks you from taking that view mid-fight, and how could you take some of it into the next round?
- [] **Calendar all three now** — e.g., after the next big fight, plus reminders around months 5 and 9. When a reminder fires, run it on the most recent significant disagreement.
- [] **Solo is fine.** Your partner doesn't have to participate or know. Done calm, between fights — nothing has to be remembered while angry.

Part 2 — The two in-fight rules

Rule one: the neutral corner. *(Evidence: Gottman Institute clinical guidance on flooding — heart rate around 100+ BPM in conflict means you cannot process social interaction; practitioner heuristic, consistent with peer-reviewed demand/withdraw and cascade findings, not trial-proven.)*

- [] **Either partner can call it**, using a signal agreed in advance while calm.
- [] **Break lasts at least 20 minutes.**
- [] **Reunion time agreed before separating — within 24 hours.** ("Back at 8:30.") The scheduled return is what makes it a break, not a withdrawal.
- [] **Spend the break calming down** — walk, music, breathing. Not replaying the argument or building your case; rumination keeps the body activated, and you'll return as flooded as you left.

Rule two: take the repair. *(Evidence: in Gottman's observational research on 3,000+ couples, as reported by the Gottman Institute, how skillfully a repair was delivered didn't necessarily predict whether it worked — the emotional climate between partners did. Observational, attributed.)*

- [] **Accept the clumsy olive branch** — the bad joke, the half-apology, the hand on the arm. Don't grade it on delivery; delivery wasn't the variable.
- [] **Offer yours without polishing it.** It doesn't need to be eloquent to land. The climate decides, not the wording.

Part 3 — The climate

(Evidence: the Gottman Institute's described antidote to contempt — the biggest divorce predictor in Gottman's observational research — and the ground the repair finding says repairs land on. Attributed, correlational.)

- [] **Near-daily deposit:** catch your partner doing something right and say so, specifically. "You handled the school call" beats "you're great." Thirty seconds, most days.

The two maintenance rules

The deliberate-exception rule. A calendar reminder fires during a genuinely calm season, with no significant disagreement to write about? Skipping is a decision, not a failure — note it, keep the next reminder. The protocol serves the marriage, not the reverse.

The relapse rule. Some month you'll look up and find yourselves three fights deep, no exercise run since spring, the signal word forgotten, no deposit in weeks. Here is the entire required response: schedule the next 7-minute exercise. That's it. You do not re-litigate the relationship, audit who broke the protocol first, or read the lapse as proof the marriage is failing — the lapse is a missed calendar event, and it costs 7 minutes to fix.

This rule is why the protocol beats resolve. Resolve has to win every fight, forever, and one loss starts the spiral that ends in the midnight search. The calendar only has to fire three times a year — and when it's eroded, it's cheap to restart. Cheap to restart is the strongest thing a fix can be.

Do this now: Print or screenshot this page. If the first exercise isn't done yet, it's 7 minutes — you've spent longer than that tonight replaying the fight.

More printable cards like this, free: [Simon Gebhart's Field Notes](#)

The full guide: amazon.com/dp/B0H7Z3657X